‘Oh Kalam, you just had a premature ejection.’ Not getting the pun, Kalam tried to explain the science. Everyone by now knew the reason and laughed. Kalam continued to give lessons on electromagnetic radiation.

In a few days we were back with the no-fire current specified squib, and the rocket was ready for launch. I was back at the block house, this time with Calla, who developed the transponder. Calla, a brilliant scientist who can rightly claim to be the father of indigenous transponders—scores of them now in space letting you talk on your mobile phone and watch television programmes—was also a master of banter. He would talk casually even during the countdown, so much that he could distract others and himself from work.

During the countdown, it was not unusual for systems heads to ask for a ‘hold’. It simply meant that there is some correction to be made to a system, and hence the launch had to be held back. Till a few minutes before take-off, the payload is power-fed by an external source. Then, about five minutes before firing, it goes into internal power mode. This is to save the precious battery that is to feed the payload. Draining the battery would mean killing the transponder and hence nil data.

As the controller, I had to take the call on switching between internal and external power. While Calla kept chatting with me incessantly in the block house, someone asked for a hold just five minutes before the launch, which meant that the rocket was now on internal power.

‘How long?’ I inquired.

‘About 45 minutes.’

‘OK, systems to go back to external power,’ I said.

‘Roger,’ said the telemetry guy, confirming that his system went into external power mode.

‘Roger,’ said the ground station man.

Without blinking, Calla too said ‘roger’, without switching back to external power.

The moment he said ‘roger’, I had to take it for granted the transponder had switched off the internal power.